Christian Messiah and the salvation of humankind (or at least members of humankind who have chosen the path of righteousness). Most people of faith regard the prediction of the Apocalypse as some form of allegory. For some, though, the prophecy of Armageddon remains the foundation of their belief. For the rest of humanity, the end of the world is the end of the world. It is not a 'Day of Judgement' to be embraced, but a catastrophe beyond imagination and language. In October 1962 we may have been close to that event. As Nikita Khrushchev observed: 'At the height of the Cuban events, the smell of burning hung in the air.'[6]

Contemporary scientific theories parallel biblical prophecy. Scientists have developed understanding of how, in a thermonuclear war, smoke and dust from fires and firestorms would lift into the stratosphere.[7] Sunlight would be blocked; temperatures would fall; the resulting destruction of agriculture would condemn humanity to starvation and virtual annihilation. This scenario acquired the name of a 'Nuclear Winter.' Scientists believe there is a threshold at which thermonuclear war would create such an environmental apocalypse. By the early 1960s Cold War nuclear arsenals far exceeded that threshold. In 1962 nothing was known about 'Nuclear Winters'. There was, nevertheless, widespread understanding that nuclear weapons posed an existential threat to human civilisation.

Self-Assured Destruction

US nuclear war plans in the early 1960s envisaged the deaths of a third or more of the world's population within six months of an attack. According to the Book of Revelation, the battle at Armageddon entailed the deaths of a third of the world's population. Yet, just as Armageddon was only the opening phase of the Christian apocalypse, thermonuclear war would have been only the opening phase of the nuclear apocalypse. In October 1962, even if the US military had successfully destroyed every single Soviet target, the consequences for the US would still have been apocalyptic. While the effects might not have been immediate, they would have inexorably entailed what the climatologist Alan Robock termed Self-